members did not have a substantial footprint in terms of manpower in Afghanistan, their acumen with regard to small unit tactics and explosives meant even a small number of men could have significant influence. The group's bomb-makers are also known to be among the best in the region, according to Western diplomats and security officials. They assert Lashkar's 'bomb jockeys' (to steal the term one of them used) became responsible for building some of the improvised explosive devices used in Afghanistan as well as instructing others on how to do so.[89] Notably, there was an influx of Western recruits into the Tribal Areas beginning in mid-2006.[90] Some of Lashkar's trainers and explosives experts are believed to have begun working with al-Qaeda to instruct would-be Western terrorists, though whether they were always doing so with the blessing of the leadership or were occasionally working in a freelance capacity remains unclear.[91]

Joint training signaled an expanding Lashkar presence in North and South Waziristan, where al-Qaeda and the Haqqani Network were based. The group also had a strong presence in Bajaur, thanks to historical relationships with JuDQS and Jamaat-ul-Mujahideen, and Mohmand, where the Shah Sahib group operated. These two tribal agencies constituted a recruiting ground, as well as a base for housing recruits before infiltrating them across the border. Its members developed a high-degree of integration and cooperation with other actors operating in these agencies as well, including the TTP, the Taliban, and operatives from al-Qaeda.[92] Along with growing its presence in the Tribal Areas, JuD established additional mosques, madaris, schools and offices throughout the NWFP and built up its relief efforts in the region.[93] This infrastructure was used for missionary work, the provision of social services, and to recruit for the Afghan jihad. For example, the group is known to have recruited in the Lower Dir and Swat districts of the NWFP, where local interlocutors assert those who joined were sent primarily to Kunar province.[94] Lashkar also reclaimed a foothold in the Peshawar scene where its members were able to link up with Afghan Salafis connected to JuDQS who were moving men across the border, via Bajaur and Mohmand, to fight in Kunar.[95] Outside of the NWFP and FATA, Southern Punjab was by this time becoming a feeder for the fight in Afghanistan, and Lashkar recruiters stepped up efforts there too.[96]